

Peer Mentoring Toolkit

Pilot-ready guidance for first-year belonging, low-threshold peer support and referral within Odisee Brussels' first-year support pathway

ODISEE BRUSSELS - STUDENT SUCCESS PROJECT 2025-2026
DELIVERABLE 1 OF 3 - PART OF THE INTEGRATED FIRST-YEAR SUPPORT CHAIN
PILOT-READY VERSION ALIGNED WITH THE CASE STUDY PAPER

Toolkit at a Glance

Peer connection > Check-in > Support conversation > One small next step > Navigation or referral > Follow-up

Purpose of this deliverable

1. Strengthen first-year students' sense of belonging through low-threshold peer contact. 2. Structure Odisee's existing buddy or peer-support practices without replacing them. 3. Help peer mentors guide students toward appropriate support when ordinary peer support is not enough.

Pilot-ready guidance for Odisee Brussels' first-year support pathway

Positioning Note

This Peer Mentoring Toolkit translates the peer mentoring deliverable described in the case study into a pilot-ready, low-burden tool for Odisee Brussels. It is designed to help second-year or senior students support first-year students through approachable check-ins, shared transition experience, role clarity and referral guidance.

The toolkit does not create a new large-scale peer mentoring programme from scratch. It also does not replace Odisee's existing buddy, peer-support or student support practices. Instead, it structures and strengthens what may already exist by clarifying the peer mentor role, offering check-in prompts, setting boundaries and connecting peer support to the wider first-year support chain.

This deliverable responds most directly to the barrier of relational disconnection and weak belonging. It also supports the other two deliverables. The Early Alert and Follow-Up Protocol provides a structured route when visible concern signals need staff-led follow-up. The First-Year Self-Regulated Learning Guide gives student-facing guidance on study routines, help-seeking and support navigation.

The toolkit is intended for a small pilot in one or two first-year programmes before wider use. It is deliberately adaptable because peer-support practices may differ across programmes and campuses.

Role alignment with the case study

This toolkit follows the support-role definitions clarified during the field visit and partner meeting. Buddy or peer-support actors provide low-threshold peer connection only. If a concern goes beyond ordinary peer support, the peer mentor should not solve it independently. The student should be directed to a student coach or programme coordinator for initial intake and redirection. Course-content questions should go to lecturers; study routines, learning strategies and academic integration should be connected to learning coaches; individual study-path questions should go to trajectory counsellors; language-related barriers should be directed to language coaches; and complex wellbeing, financial or practical concerns should be routed to student support services.

1. Toolkit at a Glance

Step	Simple logic	Main actor
1	A first-year student is connected to a peer mentor through an existing buddy or peer-support practice.	Programme coordinator / peer mentor
2	The peer mentor makes a low-threshold first contact.	Peer mentor
3	The mentor uses check-in prompts to discuss belonging, study routines, practical concerns and support awareness.	Peer mentor and student
4	The mentor helps the student identify one small next step.	Peer mentor and student
5	If the student needs more than peer support, the mentor guides the student to the right support route or contacts the student coach or programme coordinator.	Peer mentor / coordinator
6	The mentor records only a short reflection or, where needed, a factual referral cue.	Peer mentor / coordinator

Intended users

Second-year or senior peer mentors or buddy actors, first-year students, student coaches, learning coaches, lecturers, programme coordinators or designated implementation leads, trajectory counsellors, language coaches and student support services involved in first-year student support at Odisee Brussels.

When it is used

The toolkit can be used during orientation, early first-year transition, preparation for first assessments, moments of reduced engagement, or any point where first-year students need approachable guidance before formal support is needed.

Connection to the case study

This toolkit responds to relational disconnection and weak belonging. It supports Objective 2 by providing a pilot-ready support tool and Objective 3 by offering practical role descriptions, check-in prompts, referral cues and implementation guidance.

This toolkit is not

a replacement for Odisee's existing buddy or peer-support practices;
a full new mentoring programme requiring major extra capacity;
peer tutoring or course-content teaching;
counselling, case management or crisis support;
a monitoring or disciplinary system.

2. Purpose, Scope and Safeguards

Purpose

The purpose of this toolkit is to make peer support more consistent, approachable and connected to Odisee Brussels' first-year support pathway. First-year students do not always approach formal support immediately, even when help is available. A peer mentor can provide a low-threshold first contact who helps students feel less alone, ask questions earlier and identify the right support route when needed.

The toolkit helps peer mentors support belonging and help-seeking without making them responsible for specialised support. It gives mentors a clear role, practical prompts, referral cues and message templates so that peer support remains useful, safe and feasible.

Scope

This toolkit is intended for a small pilot in one or two first-year programmes at Odisee Brussels. It can be adapted to existing buddy systems, orientation activities, programme-level peer support or student support initiatives.

The toolkit does not require new technology, a new staff role or a full academic-year mentoring programme.

Programmes can decide how frequently check-ins happen and how students are matched, depending on existing practices and capacity.

Safeguards

Safeguard	How it is applied
Low-threshold support	Peer mentoring should feel approachable and informal, while still having clear structure. The first contact should be framed as support, not assessment.
Role clarity	Peer mentors are second-year or senior students who listen, share experience, guide and refer. They are not lecturers, tutors, counsellors, case managers or crisis responders.
Student autonomy	First-year students may accept, decline or pause peer support. They should not be pressured to disclose personal information.
Boundaries and privacy	Mentors should not collect sensitive personal information. Any referral note should be short, factual and shared only with the student coach or programme coordinator where needed.
Referral when needed	Concerns that go beyond ordinary peer support should be passed to the student coach or programme coordinator for intake and redirection, or to the relevant support actor according to local procedures.
Feasible workload	The toolkit uses short check-ins, ready-to-use prompts and simple templates so that peer support does not become a heavy parallel system.

3. Design Rationale: Evidence to Design

The Peer Mentoring Toolkit was developed from the same evidence base used in the case study. It translates research on belonging, peer mentoring, help-seeking and first-year transition into practical tools that can be adapted to Odisee Brussels.

Evidence source from the case study	Key insight	Design response in the toolkit
Tinto's student retention perspective	Persistence is shaped by academic and social integration within the institution. Disconnection can develop before formal dropout.	The toolkit positions peer mentoring as a social integration tool that helps first-year students feel connected earlier.
Belonging literature, including Gopalan and Brady (2020)	Sense of belonging is linked to engagement, wellbeing and use of support services.	The toolkit includes low-threshold check-ins and conversation prompts focused on belonging, confidence and support awareness.
Peer mentoring literature, including Crisp and Cruz (2009) and Collings et al. (2014)	Peer mentoring can support transition, integration and persistence when roles and support structures are clear.	The toolkit provides a peer mentor role card, check-in structure, boundaries and referral cues.
Help-seeking literature, including	Students may delay asking for help because they are unsure where to go or	The toolkit includes warm message templates and prompts that help students

Evidence source from the case study	Key insight	Design response in the toolkit
Karabenick and Knapp (1991)	feel uncomfortable approaching formal support.	name difficulties and move toward appropriate support.
Odisee partner brief and stakeholder input	Odisee Brussels wants to improve first-year study efficiency and prevent unnecessary dropout, while keeping support feasible. Existing peer-support practices may already exist and differ by programme.	The toolkit is designed as an adaptable framework that structures and connects existing practices rather than replacing them.
Limited informal student input	Students described friends and group chats as useful informal support. They also suggested that difficulties can remain unnoticed unless students speak up.	The toolkit turns informal peer connection into a more reliable first support route, while connecting concerns to staff or support services when needed.
Feasibility considerations from field visit and partner feedback	Support tools should fit existing institutional capacity and avoid creating heavy staff workload.	The toolkit uses short preparation, simple check-in prompts, clear boundaries and a designated referral route.

Core sources: Tinto (1975), Gopalan and Brady (2020), Crisp and Cruz (2009), Collings et al. (2014), Karabenick and Knapp (1991), Odisee (2026), partner feedback and limited informal student conversations. Full references are provided in the reference list at the end of this deliverable.

4. Toolkit Components

Component	Main user	Purpose	Output
Peer mentor role card	Peer mentor	Clarify what the mentor does and does not do.	Shared understanding of the mentor role.
Boundaries and confidentiality guide	Peer mentor / coordinator	Prevent role overload and unsafe promises of confidentiality.	Clear referral boundaries.
Suggested check-in structure	Peer mentor	Give mentors a repeatable structure for conversations.	More consistent peer contact.
Conversation prompts	Peer mentor	Help mentors ask useful questions without sounding formal or intrusive.	Better support conversations.
Referral cues	Peer mentor / coordinator	Identify when a concern goes beyond ordinary peer support.	Safer handover to staff or support services.
Connection guide to Deliverable 2 and 3	Peer mentor / coordinator	Clarify when to use the Early Alert Protocol or the First-Year Self-Regulated Learning Guide.	Integrated support pathway.
Message templates	Peer mentor	Make first contact and follow-up easier.	Low-burden communication.
Short referral or handover note	Peer mentor / coordinator	Record only essential factual information when a concern needs staff support.	Clear, minimal handover.
Peer mentor reflection form	Peer mentor	Help mentors reflect on support quality and role boundaries.	Feedback for pilot improvement.
Pilot evaluation indicators	Coordinator / support services	Assess usability, clarity and feasibility.	Evidence for refinement after the pilot.

5. Roles and Boundaries

The toolkit works only if each actor understands both their responsibility and their limits. Peer mentors are important because they can be more approachable than formal support services, but they should not carry specialised concerns alone.

Actor	Who they are	Main responsibility	Boundary
First-year student / mentee	A first-year student at Odisee Brussels, especially a student who may benefit from low-threshold transition support.	Receives peer support, asks questions, chooses whether to accept support and identifies next steps with the mentor.	The student is not required to disclose personal difficulties and may decline peer support.
Peer mentor	A second-year or senior student who has already experienced the first-year transition.	Provides approachable check-ins, listens, shares transition experience, helps identify one small next step and guides the student toward support routes.	The peer mentor is not a tutor, counsellor, case manager, crisis responder or replacement for student support services.
Programme coordinator / designated implementation lead / student coach	The staff actor responsible for adapting and coordinating the pilot in a selected programme, together with the student coach where intake and redirection are needed.	Adapts the toolkit, prepares mentors, receives referral cues, prevents duplicated contact and connects concerns to the right support actor.	The coordinator or student coach does not need to solve every concern personally, but ensures that the right support route is activated.
Lecturers	Lecturers involved in first-year teaching.	May refer students to peer mentoring or share visible concern signals with the coordinator where appropriate.	Lecturers are not responsible for ongoing mentoring or informal peer support.
Student support services	Existing Odisee support actors for specialised wellbeing, financial or practical support, alongside learning coaches for study habits and language coaches for language barriers.	Provide specialised support when peer support is not enough.	Student support services are not responsible for every informal peer question, but provide guidance for complex or specialised concerns.

Peer Mentor Role Card

A peer mentor can

welcome a first-year student and create a low-threshold contact point;

listen without judgement;

share relevant first-year transition experience;

help the student identify one small next step;

encourage help-seeking when the student is unsure where to go;

guide the student toward the First-Year Self-Regulated Learning Guide for study routine, help-seeking and support navigation guidance;

notice referral cues and contact the student coach or programme coordinator when a concern goes beyond peer support.

A peer mentor should not

teach course content as a tutor;

diagnose academic, personal, financial or wellbeing problems;

act as a counsellor or case manager;

promise absolute confidentiality when serious support needs or safety concerns are involved;

handle urgent, specialised or crisis concerns alone;

collect sensitive personal information;

replace lecturers, student coaches, learning coaches, programme coordinators or student support services.

Core role definition

A peer mentor is a low-threshold relational support actor. In this toolkit, a peer mentor refers to a second-year or senior student who supports first-year students through approachable check-ins, shared transition experience and guidance toward appropriate support routes.

6. Suggested Check-In Structure

The check-in structure gives mentors a simple way to hold useful conversations. It is not a fixed 21-week programme and does not require bi-weekly sessions unless a programme already works that way. The structure can be used in short 15-30 minute check-ins or longer mentoring conversations, depending on programme context.

Suggested Check-In Moments

Moment	Why it matters
First weeks of the semester	Students are still learning academic routines, campus expectations and available support routes.
Before first major deadlines or assessments	Workload and uncertainty often become visible before assessment periods.
After early assessment feedback	Students may need help interpreting feedback and identifying next steps.
Mid-semester	Patterns of absence, workload pressure or weak belonging may begin to appear.
Before exams or final assessment period	Study planning, stress and help-seeking become especially important.
After a referral cue or student request	A check-in can help the student move toward the right support route.

Five-Step Check-In Flow

Step	Action	Mentor prompt
1. Welcome and personal check-in	Start with the student's general experience, not immediately with grades.	"How have the last few weeks been for you?"
2. What is coming up?	Ask about deadlines, classes, group work, exams or practical pressures.	"What is coming up soon that feels important or difficult?"
3. Main concern or question	Let the student name one issue they want to discuss.	"Is there one thing you would like to figure out today?"
4. One small next step	Help the student choose a realistic action before the next contact.	"What is one small step you could take this week?"
5. Confirm contact or support route	Close by confirming the next meeting, message or support route.	"Would it help to check in again, or should we look at who you could contact?"

The aim is not to solve everything in one conversation. The aim is to help the student feel less alone, make the next step clearer and connect to support when needed.

7. Conversation Prompts and Referral Cues

Conversation Prompts

The following prompts can be used flexibly. Mentors do not need to ask every question. They should choose prompts that fit the conversation.

Focus area	Possible prompts
Belonging and connection	"Do you feel connected to people in your programme?" "Is there anything that makes it hard to ask questions in class or in your group?"
Study routines and workload	"How are you keeping track of deadlines?" "Are there moments where the workload becomes difficult to manage?"
Academic adjustment	"Is anything about studying at Odisee different from what you expected?" "Are course expectations clear at the moment?"
Support awareness	"Do you know where you would go if you needed academic or personal support?" "Would it help to look together at which support route fits your situation?"
Practical pressures	"Are commuting, work, finances or other responsibilities making study routines harder?"
Confidence and help-seeking	"Is there a question you would feel more comfortable asking a student than a lecturer?" "What would make it easier to ask for help earlier?"
Next step	"What is one thing you can do before we check in again?"

Referral Cues

Referral cues are not labels for students. They are signs that a peer mentor should involve the student coach or programme coordinator, or guide the student toward a support route.

Situation	Recommended response
Student has ordinary first-year questions about campus, deadlines, group work or study routines.	Continue peer mentor support and help the student identify one small next step.
Student does not know which support service to contact.	Use the First-Year Self-Regulated Learning Guide or help the student find the relevant support route.
Student describes repeated workload difficulty, confusion about expectations or difficulty keeping up.	Encourage the student to contact the learning coach or relevant study support route. If repeated concern signals are visible, inform the student coach or programme coordinator.
Student repeatedly does not respond, misses check-ins or appears to withdraw from participation.	Do not classify the student independently. Share the concern cue with the student coach or programme coordinator, who can apply the Early Alert and Follow-Up Protocol where appropriate.
Student shows visible distress or discloses a serious wellbeing, financial, housing, safety or crisis concern.	Do not handle alone. Contact the student coach, programme coordinator or student support services promptly according to Odisee's internal procedures.
Student declines peer support.	Respect the decision. Share one support route they can use later and close the peer check-in without pressure.

Important Boundary

Peer mentors may notice concern cues during check-ins, but they do not operate the Early Alert and Follow-Up Protocol independently. They do not diagnose, classify risk or manage cases. When a concern goes beyond ordinary peer support, the mentor uses the referral cue guidance and contacts the student coach, programme coordinator or relevant support actor, who then applies the Early Alert and Follow-Up Protocol where appropriate.

8. Connection to the Other Deliverables

This toolkit is one part of the integrated first-year support chain.

Deliverable	Role in the support chain	Connection to Peer Mentoring Toolkit
Deliverable 1: Peer Mentoring Toolkit	Builds connection, trust and low-threshold peer support.	Peer mentors provide the first approachable contact and help students identify next steps.
Deliverable 2: Early Alert and Follow-Up Protocol	Makes repeated or serious concern signals visible and guides warm follow-up.	If a mentor notices concern cues beyond ordinary peer support, the mentor contacts the student coach or programme coordinator. The formal follow-up route belongs to Deliverable 2.
Deliverable 3: First-Year Self-Regulated Learning Guide	Helps students build study routines, prepare help-seeking messages and identify appropriate support routes.	Peer mentors can use the First-Year Self-Regulated Learning Guide to help students find the right academic, practical or student support route.

Simple decision logic

Peer support question -> stay within Deliverable 1. Study routine, help-seeking or support route question -> use Deliverable 3. Repeated or combined concern cue -> contact the student coach or programme coordinator and use Deliverable 2 where appropriate. Urgent or specialised concern -> refer promptly to student support services or the relevant internal procedure.

9. Ready-to-Use Templates

The following templates are designed to make the toolkit easy to use during a small pilot. They can be adapted to Odisee Brussels' communication channels, programme context and student support procedures.

Template 1: First Check-In Message

Hi [Name],

I am [Name], your peer mentor / buddy for the start of the year. I am a [second-year / senior] student in [programme], so I know that the first weeks can bring a lot of new information.

Would you like to have a short check-in this week or next week? We can talk about how things are going, what feels unclear and where to find support if you need it.

Best, [Name]

Template 2: Follow-Up After First Conversation

Hi [Name],

Thanks for talking today. The small next step we agreed on was:

[One small next step]

If it helps, we can check in again on [date/time], or I can help you find the right support route.

Best, [Name]

Template 3: Support Navigation Message

Hi [Name],

Based on what you mentioned, it may help to look at the First-Year Self-Regulated Learning Guide. It can help you think through study routines, prepare a help-seeking message and decide whether to contact a peer mentor, student coach, learning coach, lecturer, study support or student support services.

If you want, we can look at the options together and identify the most useful next step.

Best, [Name]

Template 4: Referral Cue Message to Designated Staff Contact

This template is for the peer mentor to contact the student coach or programme coordinator when a concern goes beyond ordinary peer support. It should be short and factual.

Student code/name, where appropriate: [] Date: [] Mentor name: [] Observed concern cue: [] Is this repeated or combined with other cues? [Yes / No / Unsure] Student response, if any: [] Support already suggested, if any: [] Reason for handover: []

Short factual note:

[Write only what is necessary for follow-up. Avoid sensitive details unless they are necessary for safety or referral.]

Template 5: Student Declines Peer Support

Hi [Name],

Thanks for letting me know. That is completely okay. I will not keep following up about peer mentoring unless you want to use it later.

If you need support at another point, you can use the first-year support information or contact [support route/contact].

Best, [Name]

Template 6: Peer Mentor Reflection Form

Question	Short response
Date of check-in	
Was the conversation mainly about belonging, study routine, support navigation, practical pressure or another topic?	
Did the student identify one small next step?	Yes / No
Did the student need support navigation information?	Yes / No
Did any referral cue appear?	Yes / No / Unsure
If yes, was the student coach or programme coordinator informed?	Yes / No / Not applicable
Did the mentor stay within role boundaries?	Yes / No / Unsure
What should be improved in the toolkit or prompts?	

Mentor reflection forms should be used for pilot learning and mentor support. They should not become heavy case files.

10. Pilot Use and Mentor Preparation

The toolkit can be tested in one or two first-year programmes before wider implementation. The pilot should remain small enough to be feasible, but structured enough to generate useful feedback.

Suggested Pilot Steps

Step	Action
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Step	Action
1. Adapt the toolkit	Add local programme contacts, existing buddy practices and relevant support routes.
2. Select peer mentors	Use second-year or senior students who are approachable, reliable and willing to respect boundaries.
3. Brief mentors	Provide a short practical briefing on role boundaries, check-in structure, referral cues, privacy and use of Deliverable 2 and 3.
4. Introduce the toolkit to students	Explain that peer mentoring is a support option, not a formal assessment or disciplinary route.
5. Run check-ins	Use the suggested check-in structure and prompts during key transition moments.
6. Use referral cues when needed	Mentors pass concerns to the student coach or programme coordinator when concerns go beyond peer support.
7. Collect feedback	Gather short feedback from students, mentors, coordinators and support actors.
8. Refine the toolkit	Adjust prompts, role descriptions, referral cues and templates before wider use.

Mentor Preparation Topics

Topic	What mentors should understand
Purpose of peer mentoring	The aim is belonging, low-threshold support and support navigation, not tutoring or counselling.
Role boundaries	Mentors support, listen and guide. They do not diagnose, teach, counsel or manage serious cases.
Check-in structure	Mentors can use the five-step check-in flow flexibly.
Conversation prompts	Mentors can ask about belonging, workload, support awareness and next steps.
Referral cues	Mentors should know when to involve the student coach or programme coordinator.
Connection to other deliverables	Deliverable 2 is used for staff-led early follow-up. Deliverable 3 helps students navigate support options.
Privacy and minimal notes	Mentors should avoid collecting sensitive information and should record only what is necessary.

11. Pilot Evaluation Indicators

The following indicators can be used for formative evaluation during the pilot and summative reflection after the pilot. They should be adapted to the selected programme context.

Evaluation focus	Possible indicator	Data source
Student belonging and support clarity	Students report that peer contact helped them feel more connected or clearer about where to seek support.	Short student feedback form
Peer mentor confidence	Peer mentors report confidence using check-in prompts, boundaries and referral	Peer mentor feedback form

Evaluation focus	Possible indicator	Data source
	cues.	
Usefulness of check-in structure	Mentors and students find the five-step check-in structure clear and usable.	Mentor reflection form / student feedback
Referral boundary clarity	Mentors know when a concern should be passed to the student coach or programme coordinator.	Mentor feedback / coordinator review
Connection to support navigation	Students are guided to the First-Year Self-Regulated Learning Guide when they need study routine, help-seeking or support navigation guidance.	Mentor reflection form / student feedback
Link to Early Alert Protocol	Repeated or serious concern cues are passed to the student coach or programme coordinator rather than handled by mentors alone.	Coordinator review
Workload feasibility	Coordinators and mentors perceive the toolkit as manageable during the pilot.	Staff and mentor feedback
Improvement of toolkit	Feedback leads to concrete changes in prompts, templates or referral cues.	End-of-pilot review

End-of-Pilot Review

At the end of the pilot, Odisee can review anonymised feedback from students, peer mentors, coordinators and support services. The review should focus on whether the toolkit strengthened belonging, made support easier to approach, clarified peer mentor boundaries and connected students to the wider first-year support pathway without creating excessive workload.

If the pilot is feasible and useful, the toolkit can be refined and adapted for other programmes or campuses while remaining connected to Odisee's existing buddy, peer-support and student support structures.

References

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